

TAKE ONE Go-Live Checklist

A practical launch-readiness PDF for turning the current local film crew platform into a public website.

Current status: the site has a working Express/MySQL backend, live script data, role-based UI, collaboration requests, and an SMTP-ready email layer. Before public launch, the main work is security, production deployment, profile editing persistence, moderation, and operational reliability.

Area	Current	Before Public Launch
Frontend	Interactive role UI and live scripts	Accessibility pass, mobile QA, error states
Backend	Express API with MySQL	Auth middleware, validation, rate limits, logs
Email	Nodemailer integrated	Real SMTP credentials and test inbox
Database	Users/scripts/requests tables	Migrations, backups, indexes, least-privilege DB user
Security	Password hashing exists	HTTPS, Helmet, CORS production origin, secrets rotation

1. Security System Needed

- Use HTTPS on the live domain. Never serve login/register over plain HTTP.
- Move all secrets to production environment variables: DB password, JWT secret, SMTP password, and any future storage keys.
- Install and configure Helmet for secure HTTP headers.
- Add rate limiting to login, register, search, request sending, and email endpoints.
- Lock CORS to the real production domain only. Remove broad localhost-style origins in production.
- Validate every request body with a schema library such as Joi or Zod.
- Add authentication middleware so users cannot impersonate other user IDs in script uploads or request sending.
- Add file upload validation before enabling poster/avatar uploads: file type, max size, safe storage names, and scanning later.
- Add password reset flow, email verification, and optional account deletion.

2. Backend Readiness

- Split routes into protected and public routes. Anyone can search scripts, only logged-in users can request or upload.
- Add central error logging so backend failures are visible after launch.
- Add request status actions: accept, reject, pending, cancelled.
- Make profile saving persist to MySQL. At the moment the profile edit UI needs a real update endpoint before launch.
- Add database migrations instead of manually running SQL in Workbench for every change.
- Create an admin-only area for moderation, reported users, and suspicious content.

3. Database and Data Protection

- Create a non-root MySQL user for production. Do not use root on a live server.
- Add indexes for search fields: scripts.title, scripts.genre, users.role, users.city.
- Back up the database daily and test restore once before launch.
- Separate seed/demo data from production data.
- Add soft-delete or archive strategy for users, scripts, and requests.

4. Email and Notifications

- Replace placeholder SMTP values with real provider credentials.
- Use a verified sender email like no-reply@yourdomain.com.
- Send email for collaboration requests, accept/reject decisions, password reset, and email verification.
- Add in-app notifications so users do not depend only on email.
- Keep email templates simple, branded, and mobile friendly.

5. Frontend and User Experience

- Test every role: Director, Camera, Actor, Writer, Editor, Sound, Gaffer, Spot Crew, and Producer.
- Make all important UI responsive on phones, tablets, and laptop screens.
- Add loading states, empty states, and helpful error messages for every API call.
- Add a 404 page and friendly offline/server-down state.
- Improve accessibility: keyboard focus, readable contrast, alt text, and reduced motion support.
- Add SEO basics: title, description, Open Graph image, favicon, sitemap, and robots.txt.

6. Legal and Trust

- Create Privacy Policy, Terms of Use, and Copyright/IP policy pages.
- Add clear content rules for scripts, images, harassment, spam, and fake accounts.
- Add report/block user feature before public launch.
- Add consent text for email notifications during signup.

7. Deployment Checklist

- Choose hosting: Render, Railway, Fly.io, VPS, or similar for Node/Express.
- Use managed MySQL or a secured VPS database.
- Buy a domain and configure DNS.
- Set production environment variables on the hosting platform.
- Use a process manager or platform restart policy so the server restarts after crashes.
- Enable HTTPS with the host or reverse proxy.
- Add analytics and error monitoring before marketing the launch.

8. Recommended Next Build Order

- First: secure auth middleware so users can only act as themselves.
- Second: profile update endpoint so profile edits save permanently.
- Third: request accept/reject flow and in-app notifications.
- Fourth: real SMTP test with a verified sender address.
- Fifth: production deployment with HTTPS, backups, and monitoring.
- Sixth: legal pages and moderation tools.

Launch Decision

Do not launch publicly until these three items are finished: protected backend routes, persistent profile editing, and production-grade security settings. After those are done, TAKE ONE can move from local prototype to a controlled beta launch.

Best beta plan: invite 20-50 known student filmmakers first, watch how they register, upload, search, request, and contact each other, then fix friction before opening to everyone.